

French Open Media Boycott: Top Players Unite in Pay Dispute

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The usually glitzy pre-tournament media day at the French Open took a tense turn on Friday when top players staged a coordinated protest over pay. Aryna Sabalenka, the outspoken world number two from Belarus, cut her news conference to just 10 minutes, while men's number one Jannik Sinner and four-time champion Iga Swiatek followed suit. The **'work-to-rule'** directive doing only the contractual minimum was a collective jab at the four Grand Slam tournaments, which players argue keep too much of the revenue for themselves. 'We just wanted to make our point and we are united,' Sabalenka told reporters. '15 minutes is better than zero.' The 28-year-old has been a leading voice in the dispute, recently warning that players might **boycott** a Grand Slam 'at some point.' Coco Gauff, the reigning women's champion, said she was proud of the solidarity in an individual sport. Taylor Fritz, the American world number eight, explained they acted because they 'felt ignored.' Notably, Novak Djokovic, a 24-time major winner and longtime advocate for players' rights, did not participate but voiced support. 'I have always been on the players' side,' he said, adding that very few people actually earn a living from professional tennis. The protest is the latest in a long-running battle over **prize money** distribution. While Grand Slams generate billions, players argue the percentage allocated to them hasn't kept pace. By limiting media commitments a crucial part of the sport's promotion the stars are **leveraging** their **visibility** to force a conversation. Whether this tactic will pressure organizers remains to be seen, but the message is clear: the players are done being ignored.

Word Treasure

work-to-rule -- A protest method where workers do only what their contract strictly requires, nothing extra, to show dissatisfaction without a full strike.

contractual -- Something that is written into a formal agreement that both sides must follow.

boycott -- To refuse to take part in an event or use a service as a way of making a protest.

prize money -- The cash that competitors or teams win in a tournament for reaching a certain round or winning.

leveraging -- Using something you have (like public attention) as power to get what you want from others.

visibility -- How much public attention and media coverage a person or event gets.

Background you need

In 1973, men's tennis players boycotted Wimbledon to support their union, leading to the formation of the ATP; this protest shows that collective action in tennis has a long history.

The four Grand Slam tournaments--Australian Open, French Open, Wimbledon, US Open--generate billions of dollars in revenue from tickets, sponsorships, and broadcasting rights.

Novak Djokovic co-founded the Professional Tennis Players Association (PTPA) in 2020 to give players more say in how the sport is run, since they are independent contractors and not employees.

Tennis players often earn very little early in their careers; only a small percentage make enough prize money to cover travel and coaching, which is one reason lower-ranked players strongly support better revenue sharing.

Limiting media access strikes at the promotional side of the sport, because star players attract viewers and sponsors, making their silence a powerful bargaining tool.

Break it down

LEAD: The usually glitzy French Open media day turned tense with a coordinated protest

+ specific: 'Sabalenka cut her news conference to just 10 minutes'

KEY PLAYERS: Sabalenka, Sinner, Swiatek follow suit; Fritz, Gauff voice support

+ DJOKOVIC: 24-time major winner supports but does not participate

PROTEST METHOD: Work-to-rule directive--doing only the contractual minimum

+ AIM: A collective jab at the four Grand Slam tournaments

PLAYERS' ARGUMENT: Grand Slams keep too much revenue; prize money percentage hasn't kept pace

+ SABALENKA: Warning of future Grand Slam boycott

+ FRITZ: Acted because they 'felt ignored'

SOLIDARITY: Gauff proud of unity in an individual sport

TENSION: Limiting media commitments leverages players' visibility

OPEN QUESTION: Will this pressure organizers to give players a bigger share?

Why it matters

This protest shows how even athletes in an individual sport can use their collective influence to challenge powerful institutions, a lesson in labor rights and the economics of entertainment that echoes far beyond tennis.

Test what you remember

1. What tactic did the top players use to protest at the French Open?

- ☐ (A) Refusing to play matches
- ☐ (B) Limiting media time and following only contractual minimums
- ☐ (C) Starting a new tournament
- ☐ (D) Blocking the court

2. Who cut her news conference to just 10 minutes?

- ☐ (A) Iga Swiatek
- ☐ (B) Aryna Sabalenka
- ☐ (C) Coco Gauff
- ☐ (D) Taylor Fritz

3. According to Sabalenka, how many minutes is 'better than zero'?

- ☐ (A) 5 minutes
- ☐ (B) 10 minutes
- ☐ (C) 15 minutes
- ☐ (D) 20 minutes

4. Which player supported the protest but did not take part in limiting his media time?

- ☐ (A) Jannik Sinner
- ☐ (B) Taylor Fritz
- ☐ (C) Novak Djokovic
- ☐ (D) Carlos Alcaraz

5. What is the players' main complaint?

- ☐ (A) The tournament is too long
- ☐ (B) The Grand Slams keep too much of the revenue and don't share enough prize money
- ☐ (C) The courts are unsafe
- ☐ (D) They want better food in the cafeteria

6. Which player said the players acted because they 'felt ignored'?

- ☐ (A) Aryna Sabalenka
- ☐ (B) Coco Gauff
- ☐ (C) Taylor Fritz
- ☐ (D) Novak Djokovic

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: C 4: C 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

- 1. Positive (player empowerment):** By uniting, the stars amplify their voices and could win a fairer share of revenue, helping not just top earners but the hundreds of lower-ranked players who struggle to cover costs.
- 2. Negative (risk to the sport):** Cutting media time might reduce the tournament's promotional reach, which ultimately lowers the overall money pot--hurting the same players they want to help if sponsors or broadcasters lose interest.
- 3. Neutral / analytical:** Grand Slams are non-profit organizations that reinvest income into developing tennis, stadium upgrades, and grassroots programs, making the tension between athlete pay and the sport's long-term health a complex puzzle.
- 4. Forward-looking:** If players escalate to a full Grand Slam boycott, the tournaments could be forced to negotiate a binding revenue-sharing model, similar to strikes in team sports like the NBA or the Premier League.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):